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Week 8 RRR
10.22.2026

GitHub Link: https://github.com/sdass3/econ238-portfolio
Speechify Link (substack didn't work): https://speechify.app.link/9dndXWIrv7b

Topic 14 British colonial forestry in India (1860s–1947)

The Forrest Was Not Empty

British Colonial Forestry and the Struggle for Control in India

Description

A railway sleeper and a village cooking fire depended on the same forests, but they belonged to very different economic worlds. In colonial India, the British state developed professional forestry to secure timber, regulate land, and protect future supplies. In the Himalayan region of Kumaon, those rules collided with the needs and rights of villagers. Their resistance exposed a question that no scientific management plan could answer on its own: who had the right to decide what a forest was for?

The Sleeper and the Cooking Fire

A railway sleeper is not an especially remarkable object. It is a piece of timber laid beneath railway tracks, holding the rails in place as trains pass over them. In nineteenth-century India, however, sleepers were part of an enormous project. The expanding railway network promised to connect markets, transport goods, move troops, and strengthen the British Empire's control over the subcontinent.

A cooking fire was just as ordinary. For a rural household in the Himalayan foothills, firewood could mean a prepared meal, warmth, and the ability to get through another day. The same surrounding forest could also supply fodder for cattle, grass for livestock, and materials for the household economy.

These two objects depended on the same natural resource. But the railway sleeper connected a tree to a distant network of infrastructure and imperial commerce. The cooking fire connected a tree to the daily life of a family.

The difference between them helps explain one of the most consequential transformations in the environmental history of colonial India.

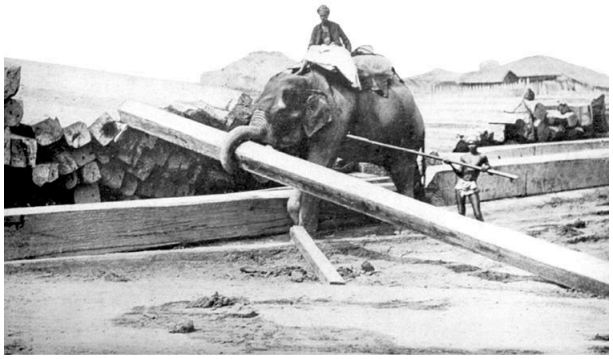
As British officials developed a professional forest administration, they increasingly treated forests as resources that the state should classify, regulate, and manage. The government wanted reliable timber supplies and worried about the long-term condition of valuable forests. Yet the laws created to manage those forests also gave officials greater power to restrict the people who already depended on them.

The result was a struggle over more than trees. It was a struggle over who had the right to decide how land should be used.

In Kumaon, a region of the western Himalayas, villagers resisted restrictions on grazing, collecting forest products, and other customary activities. Their protests became particularly intense around 1921, when fires were set in government-controlled forests. The colonial administration investigated the grievances and eventually introduced rules in 1931 that enabled the creation of village forest councils, known as *van panchayats*.

This was not the end of colonial forest control. But it showed that the government's authority was not as complete as its laws suggested.

To understand why, we need to return to the moment when forests began to acquire a new economic importance for the colonial state.



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Why the British State Wanted the Forests

By the middle of the nineteenth century, British rule in India was becoming increasingly connected to transportation, commercial agriculture, and the movement of goods over long distances. Railways were central to this transformation.

Railway construction required enormous quantities of materials. Wooden sleepers supported the tracks, while timber was used in bridges, buildings, and other infrastructure. Certain species, including sal and deodar, were particularly valuable for construction.

Forests that had long supplied nearby communities and local markets now had importance for a much larger system. A tree could be valuable to a household living close to it, but it could also be valuable to a railway department hundreds of miles away.

That difference created a problem for the colonial government. If timber was harvested without sufficient attention to future supplies, commercially valuable forests could be depleted. Officials worried about whether the state could obtain the wood it needed reliably and economically.

One response was to make forestry more systematic. Rather than simply harvesting trees wherever they were available, officials could survey forests, classify land, estimate timber supplies, and regulate cutting. They could try to manage the resource over time.

There was a genuine conservation dimension to this project. Some foresters wanted to prevent the destruction of forests and preserve their productive capacity. A forest that regenerated could continue to supply timber; one that was exhausted could not.

But conservation and commercial exploitation were not necessarily opposites. Protecting a forest could serve the purpose of ensuring that valuable timber remained available for future use.

This is an important distinction because it complicates the familiar story of environmental destruction followed by conservation. The colonial state did not have to choose between using forests and managing them. It could seek to do both, protecting some forms of forest production while restricting other uses.

The railway sleeper helps us see the incentive. The government wanted a predictable supply of a valuable resource. Yet that objective did not automatically explain why officials should decide how every person could use the forest.

To make that leap, the state needed institutions that could turn its economic priorities into enforceable rules.

Making Forests into Government Territory

In 1864, the colonial government appointed Dietrich Brandis, a German-trained forester, as the first Inspector General of Forests in India. The creation of a more organized Forest Department marked an important step toward professional forest administration.

The Indian Forest Act of 1865 gave the government a legal mechanism for bringing specified forest areas under state control. The Indian Forest Act of 1878 expanded those powers and introduced a system of forest categories, including reserved forests, in which restrictions on use could be extensive.

These laws changed the relationship between the state and the forest. Officials could increasingly survey woodland, draw boundaries, classify land, and determine which activities would be permitted.

The process might sound like ordinary administration. But classification has consequences when people already use the land.

Consider a household that has gathered firewood from a nearby forest for generations. The family may not hold a modern deed giving it private ownership of the trees. Nevertheless, its access can be part of a customary arrangement that shapes daily life.

A new law can change that arrangement. If the government declares a forest reserved and restricts gathering, grazing, or cutting, the household's established practices may become subject to permission or prohibition.

The forest has not physically moved. The trees are still there. What has changed is the household's legal relationship with them.

This is where economics helps us understand the consequences. Property rights are not simply about whose name appears on a deed. They determine who can use a resource, who can exclude others, and who has the authority to make decisions about it.

When the state changes those rights, it redistributes opportunities and costs.

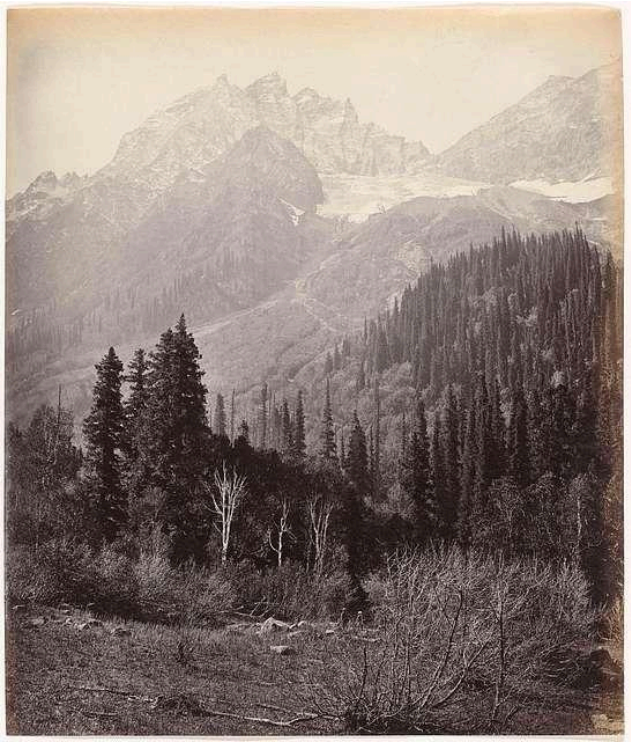
A household that loses access to nearby firewood may have to travel farther to collect it. A family whose livestock can no longer graze in a familiar area may need to find alternative fodder or reduce the number of animals it keeps. A person who gathers forest products for sale may lose part of an income source.

These consequences may not appear in the government's timber accounts. They may not involve a purchase or sale. Yet they are real economic costs.

The state could measure the quantity of timber produced and estimate the future growth of trees. It was harder to incorporate the full value of all the activities that local households carried out in the same forest.

The result was a shift in authority. Activities once governed through customary practices and local arrangements increasingly depended on rules established by the colonial government.

The important question is not whether forests needed management. It is why management came to mean that the government should have the final say.



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A Personal Connection

As someone of Indian origin, I approach this history with a connection to British colonialism that is not purely academic. My own family history includes relatives who were negatively impacted by British occupiers, which makes the question of who gets to exercise power over other people especially significant to me.

I do not want to treat every aspect of British colonial rule as interchangeable, or to assume that my family's experiences were the same as those of villagers in Kumaon. Instead, that personal connection makes me more attentive to the way colonial authority affected ordinary people's

lives. In the case of forestry, the question was not simply how to manage trees efficiently. It was also **who** had the power to decide how people could use the land and resources they depended on.

The Authority of Expertise

Professional forestry offered a compelling argument for centralized management. Trained officials could study tree growth, plan timber extraction, and regulate cutting with an eye toward future supplies. Their work promised to replace uncertain harvesting with a more predictable system.

It would be too simple to dismiss this project as nothing but a disguise for commercial exploitation. Some foresters genuinely wanted to protect forests from excessive cutting. They sometimes opposed commercial or administrative pressures that threatened long-term timber production.

But expertise in forestry could also justify an expansion of government power.

If officials believed they knew how a forest should be managed, they could regard local practices as inefficient or destructive. Restrictions could then be presented not as political choices but as the necessary application of professional knowledge.

The difficulty was that knowledge of timber production did not automatically settle every question about forest use.

A forester might know how a valuable tree regenerated but have a limited understanding of how a village household combined farming, livestock, fuel collection, and seasonal work. A rule intended to protect young trees could interfere with gathering fodder. A prohibition on burning might conflict with a local practice used to encourage fresh grass for grazing.

The problem was not simply that officials lacked information. It was that different groups valued the forest for different purposes.

A forest could be a source of commercial timber, a place for grazing animals, a source of fuel, and a collection of plants and materials used by households. These uses could overlap, and sometimes they conflicted. Deciding which should take priority was not a question that scientific measurements could answer by themselves.

The state had to make a political choice about whose needs mattered most.

Colonial forestry often treated that choice as a matter for government officials. Villagers were expected to adapt to the management system, rather than participate equally in determining it.

This did not mean the colonial government always acted as one unified institution. Forest officials, revenue administrators, railway authorities, and other officials had different priorities. Some emphasized timber and conservation; others worried about agricultural needs, revenue, or the consequences of rural discontent.

These disagreements mattered. They show that the expansion of colonial control was not an automatic or perfectly coordinated process. It involved competing goals and arguments about how the government should use its power.

Nevertheless, the Forest Department acquired stronger legal tools to determine how woodland could be used. The people most directly affected by those decisions had limited influence over the rules.

In Kumaon, that arrangement eventually became difficult to sustain.

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Kumaon: When the Rules Reached the Village

Kumaon, in the western Himalayan foothills, provides a particularly revealing case of the conflict between professional forestry and customary use.

For rural households, the forests supported a mixed economy. Agriculture was important, but so were livestock and the collection of forest products. Firewood supplied household energy. Grass and fodder supported animals. Forest resources helped sustain the agricultural system itself.

During the period from 1911 to 1917, the government transferred additional large areas of forest in Kumaon to the Imperial Forest Department. The new rules placed greater restrictions on activities such as grazing, lopping trees, collecting forest produce, and extending cultivation.

The changes affected how villagers could use resources they depended on. They also increased the reach of forest officials and made more local activities subject to government rules.

The effects were not identical for every household. A family with substantial agricultural land might face different pressures from a household more dependent on livestock or forest products. People also differed in their ability to find alternative sources of income or resources.

But the central problem remained: decisions about the use of local resources were increasingly being made by an authority that villagers had little power to direct.

This was not simply a disagreement about the best way to care for trees. It was a conflict over who was entitled to decide.

The government treated its legal authority as the basis for determining acceptable forest use. Villagers could see the same land as part of an established system of livelihoods and customary access.

When the state restricted those practices, it was not just changing the management of a resource. It was changing the terms on which people could live from their surroundings.

Resistance developed through protests and the refusal to accept some restrictions. The grievances also overlapped with wider political concerns about colonial demands on rural people, including compulsory unpaid labor, known as *coolie begar*.

These issues were connected by a common question: how far could the colonial state command the resources and labor of people who had little say in how they were governed?

The Fires of 1921

The conflict became especially dramatic around 1921, when villagers deliberately set fires in government-controlled forests. Dry conditions made some fires difficult to contain, and the burning became part of a wider pattern of resistance to colonial forest policies.

To forest officials, these fires threatened the trees and undermined plans for protecting commercially valuable forests. The burning could seem to demonstrate precisely why government rules were needed.

But the local context complicates that interpretation. In parts of the region, burning was associated with encouraging fresh grass for grazing. A practice that officials considered destructive could have a practical purpose for people who depended on livestock.

This does not mean that every fire was beneficial or that forest damage was unimportant. It means that the same action could look different depending on which resources and interests were being considered.

The Forest Department sought to protect woodland according to its management priorities. Villagers were concerned with access to resources that supported their livelihoods. Those goals could sometimes align, but they could also conflict.

The fires exposed the limits of centralized authority. The government could issue regulations and impose penalties, but it could not automatically make people accept a system that threatened their everyday economic lives.

We should not assume that every villager who participated in the resistance understood it as a modern environmental or political movement. The evidence supports a more grounded interpretation: people resisted restrictions and challenged the government's control over forest use.

Yet the broader significance is unmistakable. The state had assumed that its authority to manage forests could be established through law and professional administration. The protests demonstrated that authority depended on enforcement, cooperation, and the ability to govern a landscape in which people already had their own interests and practices.

The government could claim control of the forest. It could not simply legislate away the conflict over that claim.

When the State Had to Listen

In 1921, the colonial government established the Kumaon Forest Grievances Committee to investigate the growing discontent. The committee heard more than 5,000 witnesses and made over 30 recommendations.

The scale of the inquiry matters. The conflict had become too significant to dismiss as a minor dispute between a few villagers and forest guards. The government needed to respond to widespread grievances.

The committee's recommendations helped bring changes to forest administration, including the reclassification of forests and the transfer of some areas from the Forest Department to the Revenue Department.

A further development followed in 1931, when the Kumaon Panchayat Forest Rules provided a legal framework for *van panchayats*, or village forest councils. These councils allowed communities to seek control over designated forests and establish rules for their management.

This was a significant change. Instead of treating local users solely as people who had to obey government restrictions, the system gave village communities a formal role in managing certain forest areas.

But the outcome was not a complete restoration of customary rights. The councils operated within a framework established by the colonial state, and their powers were limited to designated areas. The government continued to exercise authority over the wider forest system.

The compromise therefore contained a paradox. Villagers gained a greater role in forest management, but that role was recognized through a legal system created by the government whose authority they had challenged.

The state had not abandoned control. It had been forced to change how control worked.

This is the turning point in the story. The village councils showed that centralized forestry was not the only possible way to govern a forest. Local communities could also make rules, monitor use, and manage shared resources.

The question was no longer simply whether a forest needed management. It was who should participate in that management, and how much authority local users should possess.

What the Conflict Cost—and Who Benefited

The history of Kumaon becomes even more revealing when we examine the distribution of costs and benefits.

The colonial government had strong reasons to value timber. Railways and other infrastructure required reliable supplies, and the state wanted to preserve the productive capacity of commercially valuable forests.

Yet the benefits of a more predictable timber supply did not necessarily accrue to the same people who bore the costs of restrictions.

The state and commercial users could benefit from regulated timber production. Villagers could bear the costs of reduced access to fuel, fodder, grazing, and other resources. Some of these costs appeared as lost income. Others appeared as extra labor, longer journeys, or fewer options for managing a household economy.

A forest management plan could measure timber production and tree growth without fully accounting for those burdens. It could appear efficient from the standpoint of timber supply while imposing costs on people whose activities were less visible in official calculations.

This resembles what environmental economists call an external cost: a consequence of an economic decision that falls on people who are not fully represented in the decision or its accounting. We should not assume that colonial officials used this modern framework. It is a way for us to understand the distributional consequences of their policies.

But the central issue goes beyond calculation. Even if officials had measured every cost imposed on villagers, a political question would remain: who had the right to decide how those costs should be distributed?

A policy may have a defensible conservation purpose and still impose unfair burdens. At the same time, local access does not guarantee that resources will always be used sustainably or that every member of a community will benefit equally.

The lesson is not that government management always fails and local management always succeeds. It is that the design of institutions matters. Who makes the rules affects what the rules prioritize, whose knowledge they incorporate, and whether the people affected have reasons to cooperate.

In Kumaon, the colonial government discovered that formal legal authority was not enough. Resistance made the system difficult to enforce and pushed officials toward a compromise.

The village councils did not settle every question about forests. They did, however, make it harder to treat local people as irrelevant to forest governance.

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A Forest Is Also a Political Institution

Kumaon was one region within a much larger colonial system. Across India, forest laws and professional administration expanded the state's ability to classify woodland, restrict access, and manage commercially valuable resources. The specific effects differed by region, depending on the kinds of forests, local livelihoods, and economic demands.

Railways were one important source of pressure, but the wider story also involved revenue, infrastructure, and the desire to make natural resources more predictable. Professional forestry supplied both techniques for managing forests and a language through which officials justified greater control.

The significance of Kumaon is that it reveals the limits of this project. The colonial state could establish legal categories, employ foresters, and issue regulations. It could not assume that the people affected would accept its priorities or that its own definition of good management would capture every important use of the forest.

The eventual creation of *van panchayats* also complicates the opposition between government and community. Local management was not necessarily the absence of rules. Village councils could establish restrictions, monitor access, and impose penalties. The difference was that local users had a recognized role in making those de

[Pause for any final questions]

Further Reading

1. Ramachandra Guha, "An Early Environmental Debate: The Making of the 1878 Forest Act" (1990). A useful account of the debates and disagreements behind colonial forest legislation.
2. Madhav Gadgil and Ramachandra Guha, *This Fissured Land: An Ecological History of India*. Places colonial forest control within the larger history of India's ecology, livelihoods, and political economy.
3. Arun Agrawal, "Group Size and Successful Collective Action: A Case Study of Forest Management Institutions in the Indian Himalayas". Explains the history of *van panchayats* and how local institutions govern shared resources.
4. Brett M. Bennett, *Empire Forestry and the Origins of Environmentalism*. Explores the relationship between professional forestry, imperial rule, and environmental thought.
5. "Forest resources and institutions," Food and Agriculture Organization. Provides additional detail on the restrictions imposed in Kumaon, the Forest Grievances Committee, and the development of village forest councils.